

Johnny Alejandro Rojas

February 20, 2026

ENGL 101-A

LaEsha Sanders, M.F.A.

### This I believe

A common struggle shared among Christians is the effort to hold faith steady when life feels uncertain. When difficulties stretch longer than expected, it becomes easy to wonder whether such trials are truly necessary. The human heart often leans toward a simple conclusion: if God desires good for His people, why permit hardship at all? From this perspective, suffering can appear like an interruption to blessing rather than a part of it.

There is a quiet habit in human nature to define what is “good” by what feels secure. A stable job, financial safety, peace within the family, restored relationships, these things naturally seem to be the signs of divine favor. They are not wrong desires. In fact, they reflect a longing for order and well-being. Yet one may ask whether these visible goods are the whole picture. Is blessing only what brings comfort? Or might it include something deeper that is not immediately pleasant?

Scripture presents God not as distant, but as One who guides with a premeditated intention. In Book of Psalms 32:8, God speaks of instructing and teaching, of watching over with care. This suggests direction rather than randomness. If divine guidance is real, then trials cannot be meaningless. They must serve a purpose that may not be obvious at first glance.

Human understanding, however, is limited. The mind tends to measure life by the moment it exists in. It sees what is missing before it sees what is being formed. It desires the gift without always considering the weight of the gift. Yet history and daily experience show that blessings given without preparation can harm. Success without discipline can inflate pride. Influence without maturity can mislead. Even love, when pursued without patience, can become destructive. In this light, trials begin to look less like punishment and more like preparation. They build a kind of

strength that comfort alone cannot produce.

An example that often stands at the center of this reflection is the life of Joseph. His story does not begin with comfort. It begins with betrayal. Sold by his own brothers, carried away from his father's house, placed in a foreign land—none of these events resemble blessing. For a season, it would have been reasonable to conclude that his dreams were illusions and that divine favor had withdrawn.

Yet the narrative does not end in the pit or in the prison. Through years of false accusation, forgotten promises, and silent waiting, something was being formed. Joseph learned administration in Potiphar's house. He learned endurance in confinement, and control of his passions. He learned discernment through suffering. None of these lessons appeared glorious at the time. Still, they became necessary.

When famine later struck the region, it was not merely a capable ruler that Egypt required, but a prepared one. Joseph's earlier trials positioned him to interpret Pharaoh's dreams and to design a plan that would preserve grain during years of abundance. The very suffering that seemed unnecessary became the means by which an entire nation survived hunger. What appeared as personal misfortune unfolded into collective preservation.

This pattern invites reflection. If Joseph had been elevated without hardship, would he have possessed the depth required for such responsibility? If his early dreams had been fulfilled immediately, would he have understood the weight of leadership? The delay, painful as it was, formed the capacity to steward what was coming.

There is also something revealing about hardship. It exposes the fragile belief that one is fully self-sufficient. When plans fail and control slips away, the heart becomes aware of its dependence. What was once an abstract idea of reliance on God turns into a lived reality. In that place, one begins to see that faith is not merely agreement with doctrine but trust formed through need of knowing what is to come.

The Bible does not present this as a theory, but as a pattern. Growth often comes before elevation. Waiting often comes before fulfillment. The fallen nature of humanity, inclined toward

self-centered desire, does not easily accept delay. Yet delay may be a form of care. What appears as silence may be instruction. What feels like denial may be protection.

The question then remains: what is truly best? Is it employment, stability, acceptance, reconciliation? These are meaningful goods, but perhaps they are not the highest good. Christian teaching suggests that what is best is shaped in heaven before it appears on earth. It is defined not only by immediate satisfaction, but by eternal purpose. The human mind cannot fully grasp that scope. It sees in fragments; God sees the whole.

From this perspective, trials begin to reflect love rather than absence. Love does not always grant what is desired in the moment. Sometimes it strengthens before it gives. Sometimes it withholds to prevent harm. Sometimes it waits until the heart is ready to carry what it has asked for.

Curiosity about suffering, then, opens the door to humility. It allows one to admit that human judgment is partial. It invites reflection on whether hardship might be shaping the soul for something greater than comfort. And in that reflection, trials no longer stand only as obstacles, but as instruments quietly building the capacity to receive what, in time, will truly bless.